

Chapter 121_1 - Old Friend

"Her body was formed from my flower petals, so she shouldn't suffer the same fate as this human skin," Chu Qingqiu said calmly, then crouched down and used the white bone to lift up the human skin from the ground, immediately letting out a very light hiss.

"What's wrong?" Ning Fuyi quickly crouched down beside her.

As she got closer, she could clearly see that fine, barely visible hairs stood up on Chu Qingqiu's half-exposed arm. Looking at the human skin, she felt Chu Qingqiu's reaction was completely normal.

The inside of the human skin was covered with densely packed worms. These worms were of various sizes, all black, with nothing left but a mouth besides their bodies. Looking closely, they had mouths full of sharp teeth and were frantically devouring the girl's remaining flesh and blood.

Ning Fuyi immediately felt the urge to retch. She couldn't stand to watch and stepped back, but Chu Qingqiu was terrifyingly calm, actually using the white bone to pick up one of the worms and examine it closely.

Jiuying, who had witnessed everything, looked disgusted and hid behind Ning Fuyi: "Isn't Divine Venerable originally a flower? Shouldn't she fear these snakes, insects, rats, and ants?"

"I was born in the divine realm - I don't fear mosquitoes and insects," Chu Qingqiu said lightly. She seemed to have figured something out and waved her hand to burn all the worms on the human skin into thick smoke before standing up.

"These creatures are called Sand Barbarian Ghost Realm¹. They're not particularly rare normally, but these from Xuanyuan Kingdom are nourished by miasma daily, making them several times more venomous."

"This girl should already be dead, which is why she was devoured by the Sand Barbarian Ghost Realm, turning into a human skin bag to harm people," Chu Qingqiu said.

"Looking at how fresh the flesh and blood is, she probably died not long ago," Ning Fuyi surveyed their surroundings. The wind and sand were gradually subsiding, the dust in the air becoming thinner, and they could already see hazy shadows several zhang² away.

Jiuying, who had been hiding behind her, suddenly shivered again. She shook the sand dust from her hair and muttered: "Strange - why do I constantly feel like countless pairs of eyes are watching us ever since we entered Xuanyuan Kingdom?"

Ning Fuyi followed her gaze and saw she was staring at a relatively low rock, so she slowly walked forward and tapped the stone wall with her fingertip.

"I also think this stone wall seems strange..." Jiuying strode forward, first leaning close to examine it, then copying Ning Fuyi's action and tapping it.

This tap was trouble - the rock that had seemed solid just moments before had a piece knocked off, exactly where Jiuying had been leaning close. So Jiuying looked up and immediately felt a rush of air to her crown, her scales nearly exploding one by one.

She had locked "gazes" with a pair of blood-filled eye sockets.

So Ning Fuyi heard a scream, and then Jiuying transformed into a streak of light and landed behind her, wrapping around her like an octopus, writhing as if covered in insects, all trace of her seductive demeanor gone.

"Be careful," Ning Fuyi quickly used immortal power to shield the three of them, then the Emei thorns in her palm spun out, immediately splitting the rock in half. The body of a man who had been half-devoured fell out with a thud, and countless worms scattered everywhere.

Some continued persistently gnawing at the flesh and blood, making the smacking sounds of hundreds of people eating. Because of the large movements from their gnawing, from a distance the half-corpse looked like it was crawling on the ground.

This time Ning Fuyi also felt so sick she almost vomited. She waved her hand to burn all the worms to ash, then endured her churning stomach to examine the corpse, looking toward Chu Qingqiu.

"Wearing white and blue robes, looks like a disciple from Heaven Profound Sword Sect³."

She waved her hand again to shatter several more rocks, but those were just ordinary rocks with no one hidden inside, and no sign of Qiu Yi either.

Chu Qingqiu's dark brows furrowed slightly: "Since these strange phenomena are all caused by the sunken Xuanyuan Kingdom, the ancient kingdom has a spirit, and the spirit must have a place to hide. To resolve this, we must find that place."

"This path isn't finished yet," Ning Fuyi pointed to one side.

Not every one of these rocks was strange. Chu Qingqiu had shattered so many just now without any bodies falling out, so trying to find one Qiu Yi among thousands of rocks would probably take several days of splitting them.

"Let's go," Chu Qingqiu clenched her palm but was the first to walk forward.

Seeing both of them had left, Jiuying lowered her arms that had been hugging herself, her narrow eyes looking behind them. She stood silently for a moment before lifting her blood-red skirt and chasing after Ning Fuyi.

The wind and sand had stopped, so the rocks no longer moved around. Apart from the whistling wind, there were no other sounds around them. The three walked for half an hour and finally emerged from the towering rock formation.

What appeared before them was a vast wasteland with cracked, dried earth stretching endlessly into the distance.

"Such a vast wasteland - which direction should we go?" Jiuying said. "Why don't I fly up to look at the terrain? Maybe I can discover something."

Hearing this, Ning Fuyi looked up and pointed at the gloom above: "If I'm not mistaken, besides miasma, that gloom should also contain the Sand Barbarian Ghost Realm from earlier."

"Never mind then," Jiuying withdrew her gaze.

At this moment, Chu Qingqiu, who had been calculating something with her eyes closed, suddenly opened them and spoke: "Xuanyuan Kingdom has existed for over ten thousand years. If I remember correctly, ten thousand years ago this place had abundant water and grass, surrounded by mountains and forests - nothing like today's wasteland and desert."

"If these ten thousand years have caused geographical changes, then the traces left by Xuanyuan Kingdom should not be on this wasteland above, but underground."

"You mean we should go down," Ning Fuyi lifted her foot to test the dried earth, creating a shallow pit.

"Exactly," Chu Qingqiu nodded at her. Just as she was about to say something, she suddenly sensed something wrong. White silk from her sleeve immediately wrapped around Ning Fuyi, then she transformed into a white shadow, the white bone in her hand gleaming coldly as she stabbed toward the person who had just emerged from under Ning Fuyi's feet.

Just as the white bone was about to shatter the person's skull, Ning Fuyi immediately shouted to stop, then shattered the white silk and flashed back in front of Chu Qingqiu, raising her hand to block the white bone.

The white bone was extraordinary in its divine power, and the Emei thorns weren't close-combat weapons, so Ning Fuyi blocked entirely with the strength of her arm, the shock making her throat taste of blood.

Chu Qingqiu had already realized what was happening. The white bone passed over the person's head at a very tricky angle, flying far away before embedding in the earth.

"Ning Fuyi!" Chu Qingqiu quickly embraced the woman's waist, using two fingers to check her pulse.

Fortunately, her heartbeat was strong - she had only suffered very light internal injuries. Just as Chu Qingqiu was about to say something, her hand was enveloped by the woman's palm, meeting phoenix eyes with a gentle smile.

"I'm fine," Ning Fuyi released her hand, then her fingertip silently traced across Chu Qingqiu's palm, causing her to tremble for an instant.

"I could have stopped myself when I sensed the anomaly - why did you need to block it!" Though worried to the extreme, Chu Qingqiu still scolded when she spoke, making Ning Fuyi freeze.

But Ning Fuyi quickly smiled again, released her hand, and stood straight: "I was afraid you might accidentally injure someone. In that instant, I couldn't think about much else."

Chu Qingqiu realized she had just used the tone of scolding a junior. Her fingertip twitched, and just as she was about to soften her tone to say something else, the person who had nearly had their skull split by her stuck out half their body and shouted joyfully at Ning Fuyi.

"Sister Ning!" It was a young woman with bright, sparkling eyes. Though her clothes and dress were stained beyond recognition by wind and sand, one could still see they were luxurious and exquisite. Around her waist was a circle of ice-crystal jade pieces that swayed silently with her movements.

Ning Fuyi didn't recognize her at first, until she saw the ornaments at her waist, then raised her eyebrows in surprise: "Baili Shiqi⁴?"

As soon as she finished speaking, the woman completely emerged from underground and rushed over to grab her and bounce around: "Sister Ning! I heard a voice earlier that sounded familiar, but I never thought it was really you!"

"It's been thirty years since we last parted, yet Sister Ning still looks so beautiful, completely unchanged!"

Baili Shiqi's originally fruit-like cheeks had grown thinner, but her eyes were still round and her dimples deep, still radiating an innocent charm. After finishing her excitement with Ning Fuyi, she noticed the other two people.

"Sister Jiuying," she said with a sweet smile, then turned to Chu Qingqiu, who was silently gripping her white bone tightly. "And who is this?"

Chu Qingqiu was still in disguise, so Baili Shiqi couldn't recognize her.

"This is..."

Ning Fuyi had just begun to speak when someone interrupted her, and she heard Chu Qingqiu say: "Su Mo."

"Hello, Miss Su. With such beauty, you must be Sister Ning's friend," Baili Shiqi said crisply.

"Shouldn't you be at Penglai⁵? Why have you appeared in this godforsaken place?" Jiuying stepped forward to defuse the situation. "Don't tell me you're wandering the martial world again and wandered here."

"This time it is, but also isn't..." Baili Shiqi's smile faded slightly, seeming reluctant to reveal everything, then said excitedly, "Sister Ning, wait here - there's someone else who wants to see you!"

She stuck her head back into the hole she had emerged from and shouted something muffled, then another person climbed up, disheveled but with a face like fresh snow. Seeing her, they froze in place.

"Sister Wenzhu, you were just talking about Sister Ning all along the way - why are you flustered now!" Baili Shiqi was too innocent to see through Liu Wenzhu's thoughts and forcibly pulled her out of the hole, dragging her in front of Ning Fuyi.

Liu Wenzhu stared blankly at the equally surprised Ning Fuyi, putting her hands behind her back. The two were silent for a long time, silent except for the howling wind.

"Yiyi, long time no see," Liu Wenzhu said softly.

Footnotes:

1. **Sand Barbarian Ghost Realm (沙氓鬼域)** - A type of parasitic creature that devours flesh and blood
2. **Zhang (丈)** - A traditional Chinese unit of measurement, approximately 3.3 meters
3. **Heaven Profound Sword Sect (天玄剑宗)** - One of the major immortal cultivation sects
4. **Baili Shiqi (百里拾七)** - A character from Penglai who has appeared in previous chapters
5. **Penglai (蓬莱)** - One of the major immortal realms, known for its powerful cultivators